College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Admissions Watch

Early Apps, Early Results

ACCORDING to a December 19 *Forbes* report by Christopher Rim, CEO of Command Education, "the limited data available from official school reporting and institutional releases offers clear themes that students should continue to watch in the Regular Decision round."

The two themes he said stood out: "Early Application Pathways Remain Highly Competitive" and "Decision Releases Differed Widely Between Top Institutions."

"MIT, for instance, admitted only 5.5 percent of early applicants, down from 6 percent last year….

"Williams' admissions rate dropped from 26.6 percent last year to 25.2 percent in this cycle, marking the second-lowest early admissions rate in the school's history.

"And at Emory University, the Early Decision I acceptance rate dipped to 29 percent from last year's 31 percent, and the number of applicants grew to a record number of 3,593 applicants (an 8 percent increase over last year).

"Notable exceptions to this trend include Columbia, where applications decreased by 6.4 percent this year, totaling 5,497, and UPenn, where applications decreased from 9,500 last year to approximately 7,800 this year."

ROUNDUP OF OTHER NEWS

According to the *Brown Daily News*, Brown U. attracted 5,406 Early Decision applicants for its Class of 2030 and admitted 890 of them for a 16.5 percent admit rate.

The dukechronical.com reported that Duke U.'s Early Decision program received 6,159 applications, admitted 847 for a 13.8 percent acceptance rate.

The *FIUNews* said that Florida International U. in Miami received 12,000 Early Action applications from all 50 states, a 19 percent increase, 22 percent more from out-of-staters. Admitted students posted an average high school GPA over the 4.0 mark and SAT scores greater than 1200.

Georgia Tech U. reports its Early Action option drew 8,700 applicants. It admitted 2,640 for a 30 percent acceptance rate.

According to the *Hub*, 553 students from 10 countries, 45 states, the District of Columbia, and Puerto Rico were admitted to the Johns Hopkins University Class of 2030 through its Early Decision I and the university's third cohort of QuestBridge National College Match scholars.

On January 5, *The Daily Northwestern* announced that "half of the Northwestern Class of 2030 were admitted" …early. Northwestern received 5,600 applicants. Sixteen percent of those admitted are first-generation students.

The *UNC News* released the Early Action numbers for the U. of North Carolina at Chapel Hill noting it received 14,931 Early Action applications for the Class of 2030. Students were admitted from all NC counties.

The U. of Virginia's Early Decision option attracted 5,108 applicants, according to news.virginia.edu. UVA admitted 1,225 for a 24 percent acceptance rate.

YaleDailyNews.com said that Yale's Single-Choice Early Action program attracted 7,140 applicants and admitted 779, for a 10.9 percent acceptance rate.

Harvard, Dartmouth and Princeton did not release their Early information.

Dartmouth's assistant vice president and dean of undergraduate admissions Kathryn Bezella told *Dartmouth News* that "Each time we release specifics about the application numbers while the application cycle is still underway, there might be a talented student who opts out of the regular decision process because they prematurely decide that the odds are against them." ■

Financial Matters

College Credit Rates Deteriorate. The financial outlook for American colleges and universities in 2026 seems to be "deteriorating" due to declining enrollment, new federal loan limits and barriers facing international students, according to Fitch Ratings.

Other factors contributing to the uncertain financial environment are public concerns about the value of a college education, affordability and declining job placement rates for graduates.

S&P Global Ratings and Moody's Ratings concur. They also note problems with rising operating costs and intense competition for students as additional factors.

Total U.S. student loan debt is about $1.75 trillion. The average borrower owes about $39,000. And a Harris poll found about three quarters of them fear they won't be able to pay off their debt. Borrowers can see what they owe at StudentAid.gov. And they can use the FSA Loan Simulator to compare repayment plans..

Debt "Default Cliff?" Some 45 percent of student loan borrowers report being pressed to make trade-offs between student loan payments and other basic needs, according to a survey commissioned by the Institute for College Access & Success. And 20 percent said they are in delinquency or default.

"These findings bring even greater urgency to ongoing concerns about a looming 'default cliff,' where an unprecedented number of

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More Fall Enrollment Trends

2024 High School-to-College Enrollment. The National Student Clearinghouse Research Center reports that the immediate enrollment of members of the high school graduating class of 2024 showed little change from the previous year. About 60 percent enrolled immediately after high school. And for previous cohorts, only 60 percent graduated within six years.

That is despite the well-documented problems with the 2024-25 FAFSA completion rate (11.6 decline by June 30.) However, disturbing gaps persisted. Students from high-income families enrolled at a much higher rate than low-income students.

Does Direct Admissions Work? There are many different types of Direct Admissions programs ranging from those offered by the Common App to those run by different states. In 2024-25, about 400,000 students in 15 states used these to enter college.

According to the National College Attainment Network, research on the Idaho Campus Choice program, launched in 2015 and that offers admissions to all high school graduates, found that the program boosted first-time undergraduate enrollment by 4 to 8 percent. In-state enrollment increased by 9 to 15 percent. But Pell Grant students registered no increase. Most gains were recorded at two-year, open-enrollment colleges.

Common App Streamline's Process. The Common App's Direct Admission program streamlines the application process and works based on student-provided data such as GPAs that attract college offers. Research found that the Common App's program boosts applications to colleges but not enrollment.

Students who received direct admissions offers were nearly twice as likely to apply to the college that admitted them; 3 to 6 percent more likely to apply if they were underrepresented minority students; 4 percent more likely to apply if they were first-generation students; and 5 percent more likely to apply if they were low-income students. However, 86 percent of applicants ultimately enrolled someplace else.

Researchers conclude that Direct Admissions is not "a silver bullet." Students still face hurdles such as affordability, advising and understanding their options.

To better understand Direct Admissions and various DA programs, see www.ncan.org/page/direct-admissions.

At the Local Level

Alma C. Up 13 percent. This past fall, Alma C. in Michigan welcomed 323 first-year students to its Class of 2029, 13 percent more than the previous year. It also enrolled 43 transfer and 17 new graduate students. Prospective students apply free and are not required to submit standardized test scores.

Alma, with 45 undergrad programs, maintains a 9-to-1 student–faculty ratio. It has been cited for the quality of its undergraduate liberal arts teaching. It is particularly known for its education, biology, psychology and business programs and "Alma Venture," which grants up to $2,500 for internships, research, study abroad or clinical experiences. Alma graduates about 76 percent of its students in six years and approximately 91 percent are employed or in grad school within three years, with a median six-year earnings figure of $45,720.

Arizona's College of Veterinary Medicine. As with other veterinary colleges in the country, the U. of Arizona's C. of Veterinary Medicine has more applicants than it has space. The college received 2,541 applications for its Class of 2029.

It admitted only 4 percent of them because it has limited space for just 110 students. The college features a three-year curriculum and early experience with animals to bolster student confidence in their skills.

Duke Admitted 5.2 percent. Duke U. in North Carolina received 58,712 applications for its Class of 2029 and admitted 1,750 students, for an acceptance rate of 5.2 percent.

Its Early Decision rate was a little higher, 12.6 percent. Its Regular Decision rate was only 4.2 percent. The range of SAT scores for new students was 1520-1570. ACTs ranged from 34-36. Female students make up 52.5 percent of the new class. Hispanic students account for 11 percent of the new class, 7 percent are African Americans, 25 percent are Asian Americans or from the Pacific Islands, while 33 percent are white and 6 percent multi-racial.

Some 11 percent are international students and 90 students were transfers. First-generation students make up 14 percent of the new class, 22 percent are Pell Grant eligible and 100 percent of students with financial need received aid.

Notre Dame Accepted 11 percent. The U. of Notre Dame in Indiana accepted just 11.8 percent of restrictive early action applicants, a record low, and a decline from 12.9 percent last year. Early apps rose by 6 percent from last year to 13,711. Of that number, 1,617 students were admitted and 2,608 were deferred.

According to *The Observer*, prospective students for the class of 2030 were notified of their admissions decisions on December 16 at 6:42 p.m., a time which, on a 24-hour timetable, corresponds with the university's founding in 1842.

SUNY's U. at Albany Welcomes "Great Danes." The U. of 2029 welcomed 2,801 first-year students to the Class of 2029. They were admitted from a pool of 35,664 applicants. The university said it was the most diverse class in its history "with 56.6 percent coming from historically underrepresented groups.

The UC System Hits New Record. Enrollment across 10 campuses in the U. of California System "surpassed" 301,000 students, a record enrollment. About 200,000 students are from California. The number of out-of-state students decreased by two percent. "These numbers reflect California's commitment to academic excellence, access, and innovation, values that have made the University of California the world's greatest research university," said UC President James B. Milliken.

Western Kentucky Community and Technical C. Attracts More Students. Western Kentucky Community and Technical C. in Paducah registered a 2.1 percent enrollment increase this past fall to 5,384 students. ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

The Future of Graduate Education: Navigating the shifting landscape, the *Chronicle of Higher Education*, digital file; $179; find at the Chronical Store.

The First-Year Experience: How to Support Student Success by Kate Hidalgo Bellows, Karin Fischer, Beth McMurtrie, Katherine Mangan and Beckie Supiano; also from the *Chronicle of Higher Education*; $179; see, https://store.chronical.com.

Miracle Children: Race, Education, and a True Story of False Promises by Katie Benner and Erica Green; ISBN: 9781250759108; $29.00; hot off the press from Metropolitan Press. The book is based on an investigation into one school's attempt to "game" the college admissions process.

Admission: A Novel by Jean Hanff Korelitz; Grand Central Publishing; paperback; $19.99; ISBN-9780446540711; first published in 2022. The main character "has the responsibility of 'winnowing the stupendously remarkable from a vast field of the only normally remarkable.'" "Raises questions about privilege, meritocracy and the human cost of selective education." ■

Financial Matters

Financial Matters

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borrowers struggle so much to repay their loans that they default on their payments in droves,' the Institute for College Access & Success concluded.

For complete survey results, see, "2025 On the Edge of a 'Default Cliff," a Topline Polling Brief."

FAFSA Filings Up This Fall. In December, the U.S. Department of Education announced that more than 5 million high school seniors have already filled out the FAFSA, up about 150 percent compared to 2023. Perhaps that's because the FAFSA form finally is simpler and it was available in September, much earlier than in the past two years.

Two years ago, the number of completed forms was zero. Last year at this time, the number was 2 million.

New FAFSA Earnings Indicator. Once students complete their FAFSA, a new feature, the Earnings Indicator, will inform them about key financial data at each institution the student selects. And if the average earning of that school's graduates is below the average high school graduate, the FAFSA will generate a "lower earnings" disclosure. More than two percent of college students attend such institutions.

"Families deserve a clearer picture of how postsecondary education connects to real-world earnings," said Linda McMahon, U.S. Secretary of Education, "and this new indicator will provide that transparency."

Post-Graduation Cost of Living Worries. What worries today's college students about their immediate future after graduation? A recent survey by *Inside Higher Education* and Generation Lab found that nearly 20 percent said affording life after graduation or not having enough work experience or internships were worries. Some 15 percent feel "overwhelmed by the pressure to succeed."

Only 11 percent of the 5,000 college students surveyed claim they don't feel any pressure about their post college life. Only 9 percent are uncertain about whether their career path is right for them. And 8 percent are not confident in their skills or qualifications, while an equal number said their mental health makes it hard for them to plan for their future.

One way for students to allay their worries is to work with their college or university's career center beginning early in their undergraduate years and to attend as many career fairs as possible.

State Money Matters

Cal Grants. Approximately 78,000 California high school seniors received early notification of their Cal Grant eligibility. It was the first time in three years students were notified early, primarily because of federal student aid delays.

"This early alert is our effort to let students know California leaders want them to enroll and succeed in higher education," said Daisy Gonzales, executive director of the California Student Aid Commission. "Our unified message is clear; we want students to enroll and claim their Cal Grant award in California."

Michigan Increased Aid. During the 2023-24 academic year, Michigan awarded $375.4 million in financial aid to 117,336 students. Its largest program is the Michigan Achievement Scholarship created in 2022.

Prior to the creation of new scholarships, Michigan was second-lowest among the states for financial aid. These programs decreased by 98 percent between 2001-2019 following the state's attempt to rebalance its budgets after the Great Recession.

New Jersey Affordability Grant. A report from the Office of the Secretary of Higher Education and the New Jersey Higher Education Student Assistance Authority found that the state-funded Community College Opportunity Grant, which helped more than 50,000 low-income students, is delivering measurable results.

These students are more than 32 percent more likely than their peers to stay enrolled, graduate or transfer to four-year institutions. ■

SCHOLARSHIP SCOOPS

College Board Expands BigFuture Scholarships. Last month, the College Board committed an additional $6.5 million to help students across the country plan for life after high school. This new investment extends the scholarship opportunities through the class of 2030, bringing the total BigFuture support to more than $32 million. Since launching in 2019, the program has granted more than $23 million to over 24,000 students in all 50 states, 60 percent from low-income families.

Florida Atlantic Expands Scholarships. A generous gift to Florida Atlantic U. will allow it to expand scholarships for its School of Environmental, Coastal and Oceanic Sustainability. It endows 150 undergraduate scholarships for juniors and seniors of the school interested in environmental science, 70 undergraduate paid internships, 90 paid undergraduate research fellowships and 10 external summer internships and other support for graduate students.

Henrick's Receives $10 Million to Build Endowment, Support Scholarships. As it approaches its 150th anniversary, Henrick C. in Arkansas received a $10 million challenge grant from Little Rock's Windgate Foundation, which will, among other things, bolster its scholarship program.

Hoolei Scholarship. Hawaii students attending Kaua'i Community College can receive a scholarship covering first year tuition. Also, the Direct2UH is available to all Hawaiian students for all 7 UH community colleges.

Milligan Puts Limits on Scholarships to Athletes. Milligan U. in Tennessee will prohibit future student-athletes from adding academic merit scholarships on top of their athletic scholarships.

"…[T]he new athletics scholarship model is ultimately designed to help us pursue excellence in competition and to offer future students generous scholarship packages that continue to make a Milligan education affordable," said Stephen Waers, president.

Music In the Air. The new Nat King Cole and Natalie Cole $75,000 scholarship will be awarded annually to one student at the Berklee College of Music.

Reed Supports Washington State Students. Reed C. in Portland, Oregon, founded in 1908 and known for its "scholarly practice, critical thought and creativity," announced an initiative to support affordability for students from Washington state.

Its Washington College Grant Match, a four-year scholarship, is worth up to $15,000 a year. It compliments other awards and scholarships including the Reed Promise, which covers full tuition for students from families earning under $100,000 a year. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

"The Agility Imperative." A report from the American Association of American Colleges and Universities on how employers view college preparation of new employees found:

• "Employer confidence in higher education is strong;"

• "Employers view higher education's role in workforce preparation and citizenship development as equally important;"

• "Employers highly value and express high confidence in graduates' ability to engage constructively across disagreement;"

• Employers place high value on graduates' preparation for an AI-enabled workforce and express strong confidence that higher education is meeting this need;"

• "Employers are more likely to hire graduates who participated in 'high-impact practices' and other applied, hands-on experiences while in college;" and,

• Microcredentials provide a clear hiring advantage."

Comings and Goings…

Willamette and Pacific Will Merge. Two schools, Willamette U. in Salem, Oregon, (with a campus in Portland) was founded in 1842 and is the oldest institution of higher learning in the West; and Pacific U. in Forest Grove, founded in 1849, signed a merger agreement creating a new U. of the Northwest. It will be the largest private university in the state, with about 6,000 students. The undergraduate colleges will continue to operate with their current names as colleges within the combined university. They will share a common administration, while operating two separate campuses, admissions requirements, academic and athletic programs. The agreement still needs the U.S. Deptartment of Education approval.

"Our work together would be about leveraging our collective strengths to provide students opportunity and to prepare graduates who are committed to using their skills and knowledge to uplift communities," said Pacific U. president Jenny Coyle.

Martin U. Put on "Pause." Financial, enrollment and cyber-attack problems have led the predominantly black Martin U. in Indianapolis to "pause" its operation and appeal for greater "community support." Its enrollment of nearly 1,000 students in 2010 fell to 223 in Fall 2023 after COVID. The school was founded in 1977 and named after Martin Luther King, Jr. and St. Martin de Porres, a Peruvian saint who worked for racial harmony.

According to *Inside Higher Education,* Martin U. was one of 15 colleges that closed last year. The two previous years saw closures of 16 and 14 others. And 14 colleges and universities merged in 2025. Financial problems and declining enrollments were the main driving forces that led to these non-profit institutions shutting down. ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Cornell's New School of Global Development and the Environment. A $55 million gift from an alumnus has led to creation of the new school that specializes in issues of agriculture, life, environmental and social sciences.

"The Ashley School will create a dynamic ecosystem for discovery, experiential learning and innovation, transcending disciplines to spark scientific breakthroughs and real-world economic benefits for New York state and the world," said Benjamin Houlton, the college's dean.

Gettysburg's New Majors. The *Gettysburgian* reported that beginning with the fall semester 2025, Gettysburg C. students (in Pennsylvania) have the option of pursuing curricula in finance, public health policy and communication studies.

In the public health policy major, "We cultivate critical thinkers to develop evidence-based responses to current and emerging public health policy challenges and consider public health through a social justice lens," Anne Douds, co-chair of the program, told the paper.

"The new communication studies program intends to foster skills in writing, media analysis, digital content creation and public speaking through a multidisciplinary curriculum that combines theory and practice."

LSU Shreveport Launches Women's Volleyball. LSUS announced it will begin competition in Volleyball in Fall 2026, "expanding opportunities for female student-athletes…."

Lynchburg's Three-Year Degrees. The U. of Lynchburg in Virginia launched two bachelor's degree programs designed to be completed in three years, in applied public health and applied educational studies.

Morehead's Three New Certificates. Morehead State U. in Kentucky offers three new certificate programs in Digital Marketing, Human Resources Management and Nutrition and Health.

Oregon's Three New Options. In 2025, the U. of Oregon launched three new programs: a bachelor of science in materials science that offers a focus on "applied science" and "real-world problems;" a MS in education specializing in clinical psychology to meet the mental health challenges of K-12 students; and a brewing innovation minor.

Texas Tech School of Veterinary Medicine. After a five-year process, the school, located in Amarillo, received full accreditation from the American Veterinary Medical Association. Most other veterinary schools educate student's "under one roof." But TT's 52-week hybrid clinical program combines campus study with experience in private veterinary practices, shelters and other locations.

Wisconsin's New College of Computing and Artificial Intelligence. The U. Wisconsin-Madison's new college "is expected to serve as a scholarly hub for the rest of campus and carry forward many core values from Liberal Arts and Sciences including intellectual curiosity, interdisciplinarity access for undergraduates across the university (not just those majoring in CAI disciplines) and serving as a catalyst for impactful cross-campus partnerships." ■

Credential Opportunities

U.S. Offers 1,850,034 Unique Credential Opportunities. According to the "Counting Credentials 2025" annual report from Credential Engine, students and others earned almost two million credentials last year.

The report identified seven distinct credential categories and 134,491 credential providers. The report counted 264,099 "Title IV, non-Title IV (of the Higher Education Act) and degrees from foreign universities;" 486,352 "certificates of completion, academic certificates and apprenticeships;" 6,892 Certification; 3,384 Micro-credentials; 14,331 occupational licenses; 52,948 secondary school seals and endorsements, public school diplomas, private school diplomas, alternative diplomas and equivalencies; and 1,022,028 badges.

The report's Executive Summary concluded that "America's education and training ecosystem is experiencing an extraordinary moment of possibility." ■

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